She-Ra and the Princesses of Power - The Third Child. BOOK 1: Rise of She-Ra

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38303188.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Catra (She-Ra) & Original Male Character(s), Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power - The Third Child. BOOK 1: Rise of She-Ra

by DozenthTurmoil

Summary

Witness a Etheria much different than the one we all know and love! A World of Wonder, Gods and War Eternal! Bear Witness to She-Ra and the Princesses of Power: The Third Child!

Prologue: The Wayward Mother



Prologue

The Wayward Mother

Shadow Weaver's ears rang as wreckage was strewn around her. When Hordak opened the portal, she wasn't expecting much, but the portal swiftly transformed into a lovecraftian vortex of fire and shrapnel. As soldiers scattered to try and recover from the chaos, Weaver lowered her shield she had raised to protect herself but also the two infants who had already emerged from the portal. The first was a beautiful blonde haired girl with blue eyes and the other was a feline girl with blue and yellow eyes complete with a thick mane of hair to complement her beige fur.

Hordak emerged from a smoldering pile of wreckage, his red eyes were filled with volcanic rage. "What...the...hell" Hordak muttered with a deep and angry snarl "happened…" he finished with an even more bestial growl. Weaver managed to calm down the First One and Thunderian children in her arms long enough to give an answer "my lord, it seems another portal converged with our own...and with rather explosive results" she said, trying to maintain her already stressed composure.

"Well find out what else crossed the portal aside from smouldering wreckage!!!" Hordak yelled at Weaver. She sighed before vanishing back into the Fright Zone to place the infants safely in her chambers. She then warped back into the chaos that was the portal site, outside the growing borders of the fright zone. The sorceress would wander the...Shadow Weaver could only describe this scene as a war zone.

Eventually, she would discover a wounded woman holding a child, no older than the two infants. The woman, despite being wounded, held a piece of metal that cut into her hand and dripped blood onto the scorched ground. Though they looked like Etherians, the wayward mother and her infant son were far from it. Weaver kept her distance as the woman pointed the metal shard at her. “What are you?” Weaver would ask of this woman. “I. Am. Human. Like my son, now stay away!!” The woman barked angrily at Shadow Weaver. Leaning her head to the left, Shadow Weaver could see that the woman killed a few horde soldiers.

Nonetheless, the woman clearly didn’t have long to live judging by her injuries, so Shadow Weaver used her dark magic to restrain the woman. “No! Please! Don’t take him!” she begged, it seemed like she was more concerned for the safety of her child than of her own safety. Shadow Weaver simply took the child from the weeping mother. “Does this child have a name?” Weaver asked, looking at the child’s green eyes. “His name is Gareth! Gareth Elinas!” the woman said, with such desperation as if the child’s name would save him. Shadow Weaver looked down at the infant boy named Gareth and could see his vibrant green eyes, they gleamed like emeralds.

“Your son will be very well taken care of.” Shadow Weaver said as she released the woman, who collapsed on the ground. The last thing the woman would see is Shadow Weaver walking away with her son, as darkness claimed her. Weaver looked down at the green eyed child. A third child? A son? Weaver could see the child calming down and looking up at her. A small smile decorated the child’s lips as Weaver realized that looking at him reminded her of the student she once had so long ago. Weaver laid the young

Gareth with the other two infants. Three children and Etheria will never be the same…

Chapter 1: A Day In the Life

Chapter 1

A Day In The Life

Founded upon the ancient bones of the Scorpian Kingdom, The Fright Zone was both kingdom and fortress, but it was also a massive machine, its many pillars belch smog to choke the skies. Despite this, the Fright Zone and the Horde itself remain the most technologically advanced force on the entire planet.

"So why can't we get things better than these ration bars!?" Gareth said with an annoyed growl as he took a bite out of his ration bar and grunted from the subpar taste. Adora simply rolled her eyes and chuckled as she sat with him and Catra. "Hey, it's not like we could just magic something better up like those princesses!" Catra retorted with a smirk before giving Gareth a kiss on the cheek. Gareth blushed softly as he ate his ration bar, a bit more encouraged thanks to his loving girlfriend.

"Besides you two should get ready for the force captain exam that's coming up! Then we'll be out in the field conquering for the Horde!" Adora said excitedly, then she noticed the two unimpressed expressions of her siblings. "Oh come on…" Adora looked to her left and then right before speaking in a quiet but harsh tone. "Are you two seriously still considering doing your little...plan? Overthrowing Hordak is not a good idea!" Adora said lowly, trying to keep such a conversation quiet. This plan existed ever since the day Gareth was fused to that strange yellow crystal, which stuck out of his chest like a piece of eldritch shrapnel, by Shadow Weaver when they were merely kids.

The plan may have existed before that incident but Adora didn't hear of it until the day after the fusion took place. Now years later, they were still talking about it. "Yeah we are!" Catra said with a coy smirk. "And who said it wasn't a good idea? Aside from you?" Gareth added with a friendly grin, Adora sighed and rubbed the bridge of her nose, as if the discussion of this plan brought her physical pain. "Well, maybe being force captains will help you out?" Adora said, bringing her hand down and trying to be encouraging with a sheepish smile. Gareth and Catra exchanged glances before they both swallowed their food. "Well I guess that's why you're the planner out of the three of us!" Gareth teased with a hearty laugh while Catra simply chuckled and looked at Adora.

"Sooooo, wanna meet us at the hangout spot?" Catra said with a smile to which Adora nodded in response. Adora got up and cleaned up the table before walking off. Catra looked Gareth in his green eyes and lovingly caressed his cheek before planting a kiss on his lips. "See you there, Gar-Bear," Catra said with a soft smile. Gareth smiled and blushed before he responded "you too Kit Kat" before giving a kiss right back. Gareth watched his love walk off and exit the room. After Catra left the room, Gareth got up from his seat and made his way to the door when the room became colder, he sighed knowing exactly who it was.

He turned around and leaned on the door frame, his eyes hooded and he repressed some level of anger when he gazed upon the Horde's Grand Sorceress, Shadow weaver. "Hello Mom" Gareth said, mentally slapping himself for once again addressing Shadow Weaver by that title. Though this time, Shadow Weaver's eyes were a bit softer in their gaze and Gareth knew exactly why. It was the same reason why Gareth's back was still sore from

yesterday. “How is your back?” Shadow Weaver said softly, Gareth’s gaze hardened in response.

Ever since he was a child, Gareth was a defiant soul. Weaver chalked it up to his human nature, and it got him in massive trouble with Hordak. In addition to a rather nasty looking nose scar, Gareth had been tortured for every major failure he had. Instead of making him obedient, this fuelled Gareth’s plan to overthrow Hordak and take the Horde for himself.

“How do you think? Hordak practically flayed me with that torture session” Gareth said with spite and a clenched fist, his green eyes shimmered with hatred, he knew very well of his adoptive mother’s manipulative nature. Gareth turned to leave and he placed a hand on a nearby pipe. “Just tell me what you want mo- Shadow weaver” Gareth said, correcting himself mid-sentence. Weaver let out a low sigh before her gaze turned into a glare of frustration. “Gareth if you cleanse yourself of distractions and be more like Ad-” Shadow Weaver was cut off by the sound of Gareth crushing the pipe and the golden light of his crystal glowing through his shirt like a flashlight shining through a blanket.

Gareth growled and looked over his shoulder, his eyes glowing gold and he gritted his teeth. “Catra. Is. Not. A. Distraction. And for the record, Adora’s going to run off one day...just you wait” Gareth growled “you keep favouring her over us and it will come to bite you in the ass.” he warned before walking off, Leaving Weaver behind as she vanished into the shadows. Gareth had his hands in his pockets as he kept walking down the hall until he stopped in front of the barracks and saw the trio. Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio, he smiles as the three were simply talking among themselves.

Gareth kept walking until he came to the hangout. This balcony, attached to one of the smoking towers, had a view of the entire Fright Zone. Gareth felt the warmth of the sun as approached his feline love and put his jacket around her. “It gets cold up here kit kat” he said lovingly and he gave her a kiss on her cheek. Catra smiled “oh you big dummy! I got fur for that” she said before kissing his cheek and purred softly “but thank you”. Adora smiled at the scene before turning her attention to the horizon. “Tomorrow we are going to conquer the whole world huh?” Adora said with a smile, Gareth walked over to the railing and took a deep breath followed by an exhale. “We sure are” he said, unaware that all of this would soon swiftly change for the worse.

Chapter 2: Hungering Glow

Chapter 2

Hungering Glow

Gareth and Catra ascended the steps to Hordak's throne room. Shadow Weaver was already there, trying to calm down the vile warlord. "My lord, the skimmer she stole can only go so far-" Shadow Weaver was cut off by the sound of Hordak slamming his fist on his throne's armrest "She has been gone for three days! Rumors of She-Ra's return had been plaguing my troops and no one knows what is going on!" Hordak roared with pure anger and frustration rooted in his voice.

By the time Hordak ended his yelling, Catra and Gareth had made it to the foot of the throne's steps. "You wanted to see us, Lord Hordak?" Gareth asked, his eyes portrayed utter disdain for Hordak. Especially given how yesterday he was tortured and blamed for Adora's disappearance. "Cadet Catra...and Gareth, I trust you are aware of the situation?" Hordak said with a cruel glare that caused Catra to keep her head down but Gareth maintained eye contact.

"A-Adora deserted the Fright Zone a-and stole a skimmer" Catra said, her voice was weak from the crying and utter stress that Adora's disappearance caused her, not to mention the torture session Gareth went through. "Yes, 3 days ago. Do you have any ideas why?" Shadow Weaver asked to which Gareth clenched his fists in frustration, to the point where they caused a bit of pain and he took a breath. Gareth locked eyes with Weaver. "It all started 3 days ago, after Adora was granted the rank of Force Captain" Gareth began recounting his story.

3 Days Ago…

Adora held the badge of Force Captain in her hand. “Well guys?” she said as she proudly displayed the badge on her coat and grinned happily. “What do you think?” she asked Gareth and Catra who were pretty happy for their sister. “It suits you Adora!” Gareth said with a grin as Catra’s eyes sparkled “we need to blow something up!” Catra said excitedly as Gareth smiled and looked at his Girlfriend. “Or something else to celebrate!” Gareth mused excitedly before a light bulb went off in his head “I got it!” Gareth said with a big toothy grin before he led his feline girlfriend and his sister to the skimmer bay.

Gareth boarded the skimmer “all aboard the Elinas Express!” Gareth said in a sing-song tone of voice as Catra playfully rolled her eyes and got onto the skimmer. Used to the antics of her younger siblings, Adora boarded the Skimmer “so, any ideas Gareth?” Adora coyly asked before Gareth did one of his sly smirks and slammed the boost forward and the skimmer shot off.

Adora clung to the Skimmer’s railing, Catra grinned and felt the wind flow through her hair and Gareth maintained course towards the whispering woods. This was enemy territory and they all knew this, Gareh and Catra didn’t mind but Adora did. “G-guys?! Aren’t we going a bit fast!? And into the Whispering Woods!?” Adora yelled, worried but Gareth chuckled “come on! Live a little!” he said in his usual carefree tone of voice that Adora has grown so used to.

Adora gripped the railing for dear life before she felt the skimmer slow down to a stop and she opened her eyes. “Here we are,

there’s a special part of this forest that’s pretty isolated from the rest of the whispering woods. Safe from prying eyes” Gareth explained as he got off the skimmer and rolled his shoulder. Catra and Adora hopped off the skimmer, Adora gave a cautious look at her surroundings.

“Why are we here?” Adora asked as Gareth looked at the eerie looking grove. “Well, I thought it would be nice to see the whispering woods before anyone else in the horde does, you know?” Gareth said with a smile. Catra nodded in agreement “yeah you’re right! Also gotta pick prime real estate once we take over the horde!” Catra excitedly said, Adora merely rubbed her forehead before she peered into the woods. Something ensnaring her attention like thorny tendrils

“Adora? What’s wrong?” Gareth asked her before both him and Catra noticed a blue glow coming from the woods. “Oooh...that ain’t good” Gareth said as Catra tilted her head. Adora kept walking towards this light, which Gareth and Catra took notice of. “Adora?!” Catra said as Adora walked towards the thorned barrier where the blue light began to glow hungrily.

Catra tried to pull Adora back as she dragged Catra with her, Adora was in a zombie like trance. Gareth pulled Adora into one of his vice-like hugs, but instead of showing affection, it was to prevent Adora from getting closer. “Adora!! Get away from that!” Gareth growled like a beast as Catra slapped their sister across the face, which finally snapped the control the light had over Adora. “H-huh?!” Adora sputtered, Gareth and Catra let out a sigh of relief. “We’ll explain later Adora, let’s just get outta here” Catra muttered, running her hand through her hair. The three boarded the skimmer and returned to the Fright Zone

Present Day

"And that night, she was gone" Gareth said with clenched fists, he felt responsible for what had occurred, but he also felt anger towards that...glow. "That damn thing, whatever it was...it took her mind and I am going to make this world bleed for it" Gareth growled. Catra was silent but nodded in agreement. The two would witness Hordak stand up, grab something from a compartment of his throne and approach them. "Well then, I look forward to what you will both do..." Hordak said before handing them both Force Captain Badges "Force Captains" he finished his sentence, looking down upon them.

Gareth and Catra both exchanged glances and grinned. They were both one step closer to taking over the horde and when they do they will drown the world in a storm of fire and blood. Gareth and Catra put on their badges and saluted Hordak as Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes, she knew this was a very bad idea...for Hordak's Sake

Chapter 3: Into The Breach

Chapter 3

Into the Breach

It's been a long and stressful week since Adora went missing, Gareth went to orientation as Catra was too distraught to do so. Gareth's Orientation wasn't a total waste of time as he did make a new friend, someone who was much like himself. "Hey Gareth!" a cheerful voice called out to him, Gareth smiled and looked over his shoulder to see Scorpia.

"Hey Scorpia, you ready?" Gareth asked before he turned to look at Kyle, Lonnie, Rogelio and Scorpia. "Operation cheer up Catra is ready boss!" Kyle said, smiling excitedly. Being called boss has a ring to Gareth's ears, one he liked "Oh, I love the sound of that! Now then, cut out the lights, she will be here any second!" Gareth whispered as Lonnie turned off the lights to the barracks right on cue as Catra walked in a minute later. Catra's expression was full of sadness before the lights turned on. Gareth, Scorpia and the trio jumped out from the shadows "Surprise!" they all said, Catra was taken back a bit but her expression immediately softened and became warmer as opposed to the cold sad look she had not merely a few seconds ago. "Hey guys, what's going…" her words drifted off as she saw the cake being held by Kyle.

"Gareth had the idea of making a cake from all our rations! We hope you love it!" Scorpia explained joyfully as Catra smiled softly "aww you guys!" she said happily, sitting down with them as Scorpia cut the cake with her claws. Scorpia had gotten to know Catra but not to the extent that Gareth and Scorpia got to know each other. "So uhhh...is it okay I call you wildcat?" Scorpia asked

with a nervous chuckle as the trio exchanged glances and Gareth quietly ate his slice of cake. Catra smile "sure, juuust no hugs without my say so, cuz only my Gar-Bear can give me hugs!" Catra declared which caused Gareth to blush in response. This little exchange caused Scorpia's eyes to sparkle softly "aww you two are so cute!" Scorpia said with a giddy smile.

The moment the cake was finished, the rally signal was heard across the Fright Zone. "Couldn't have timed that as well even if I tried!" Gareth mused happily before getting up. It was time for a major operation, one that had been in development by Hordak and Shadow Weaver for some time. It will also be the first operation for Gareth, Catra and Scorpia.

Operation Breach is Hordak's latest attempt to get past the whispering woods and into the mythical kingdom of brightmoon where the Goddess Queen Angela leads the rebellion. Breach would involve Tanks, firepower and lots of troops...as well as potential casualties. They boarded their tanks and made their way to the whispering woods, a few hours into the journey, Gareth sharpened his Greataxe. A personalized weapon he got from Hordak as a 'show of faith' but Gareth knew it was Hordak's attempt to buy his loyalty. Catra inspected her pistols as Scorpia made sure her heavy laser gun was in good shape.

The three force captains and the trio were riding in the transport section of a Horde Tank. Gareth knocked the back of his fist against the wall behind him, which separated the drivers from the rest of the tank. A slit opened as Gareth looked at one of the drivers. "What's the weather out there?" Gareth asked, setting his greataxe down. "We got an immensely dense fog and pouring rain from an overhead lightning storm, so I'd say shit's fuckey sir!" the driver explained to Gareth, who nodded in response.

“Carry on driver, I fear that trouble is gonna find us long before we find it” Gareth said, the driver nodded and closed the slit. Gareth looked to his squad with a solemn glance as he felt Catra lean on him, she purred softly. Gareth, looking at her, put his arm around her and pulled her close. Before long, the thundering storm and pouring rain was accented by the distant sounds of gunfire and the booms of cannon fire.

“Shit! Sounds like the rebels are attacking the others!” Lonnie explained, brandishing her shotgun as Scorpia held her laser gun close, like a comforting blanket. “Eyes up people and hold on tight!” Gareth yelled as Catra began to mentally fortify herself for the horrors she was no doubt going to witness. The group began to wonder if the simulations back at the Fright Zone were going to be accurate or if it was going to be horribly underestimating the violence they were going to see.

Without warning, the sounds of violence suddenly became close as soldiers outside the tank yelled and opened fire. Their screams were cut short as the telltale sounds of arrow thunks were heard, swiftly silencing them. The loud and deafening sound of tearing metal was followed by strange energetic sounds, indicating that the other tank was being torn apart.

Gareth, a part of him knowing they were next, took a deep breath before the Drivers began to scream. The Tank lurched forward and began to lift, causing the team to grasp onto anything to prevent them from falling towards the tank’s rear doors before the Tank was violently thrown like a soft ball and began to roll.

Catra shut her eyes tightly and held onto Gareth for dear life as

the Tank crashed into what they assumed was a building. For a brief moment, All Gareth could see was darkness.

Gareth opened his eyes as his ears rang, the tank was on it's side and the lights were off. Gareth clenched his fist, raised it and opened his hand to create a small mote of golden lightning in his hand, he spoke over his own pain.

"Anyone who isn't dead, sound off" Gareth said, his voice drifting off as he tried to repress the sensations of pain his body felt. Gareth felt relief to hear the sounds of Catra, the Trio and Scorpia. Rogelio growled as he got up. "Yeah I gotta agree with Rogelio, what the fuck hit us?!" Lonnie shouted as Catra opened the slit to check on the Tank's drivers. "Fuck! The drivers are dead!" Catra shouted, gritting her teeth as her shoulder hurt like hell.

"Seems like we got lucky...no one's hurt aside from the drivers" Kyle said, albeit a bit grimly. Gareth walked over to the rear doors and kicked them open, the two metal doors flew off their hinges and tumbled into the fog, vanishing out of sight with loud metallic thuds.

Gareth and his squad stumbled out of their ruined tank to see the remains of the village they were in and that they were the only survivors of their entire platoon. "These were good soldiers...Team? Ready up, grab supplies and secure the perimeter" Gareth said, the sounds of gunfire becoming less and less frequent. "They aren't done with us yet."

Chapter 4: A Sister's Betrayal

Chapter 4

A Sister's Betrayal

Gareth and his team stood in the ruins of their platoon, corpses everywhere as the only thing illuminating the storm ridden fog was the burning husks of the tanks. Gareth gripped his axe tightly, Kyle was standing next to him sweating bullets as his Sniper shook in his hands and Scorpia was paralyzed with absolute fear.

"Form a circle, Scorpia! Behind me! Catra, by my side. Keep your weapons armed and-" Gareth was cut off by the sound of oncoming footsteps that were getting closer and closer. Everyone pointed their weapons forward as Gareth lowered his axe and pulled out his pistol, aiming it at the oncoming figures.

Their silhouettes came closer and closer, their details becoming more and more readable. The left figure appeared to be an Archer, the right figure was very womanly but it was the central figure that brought dread to the hearts of Gareth and Catra, they refused to believe the sight that was standing before them. Adora looked at them with eyes as wide as tank treads. "Catra? Gareth?" she asked them, her voice was full of disbelief. Gareth and his team lowered their weapons ever so slowly, as Adora and the two figures didn't display any hostility...yet

"Wait, those two are your siblings?" the female asked Adora, looking at her. Catra took a few steps forward "Adora? You're with them now?!" she yelled in disbelief "we thought you were dead!!"

she continued, tears welling up in her eyes. Adora stepped forward towards them. “Catra, Gareth...guys” she began holding the female’s hand “The Horde...it’s evil! We’ve been taught a lie!” Adora explained as the Female nodded, she looked at the group. “My name is Glimmer and I am the princess of Brightmoon. This is my friend Bow” Glimmer said, extending her arm to the archer.

“We are friends of Adora, we can grant you a new home if you leave the horde and join us!” Bow said with a friendly smile. Gareth looked at his surroundings and walked up, standing next to Catra. “We know the horde is evil Adora, you’ve been coddled so much by Weaver that...well you failed to notice” Gareth explained with a shrug. “Please come back with us Adora! You have us...please” Catra said extending her hand forward, Adora looked at Catra’s hand and shook her head. “I’m not coming back with you” Adora said “leave these woods and these people alone” Adora continued, her voice becoming cold as her expression became a glare.

Gareth sighed “No, we have our orders. Team...set weapons to stun” Gareth ordered as he brandished his axe and Catra armed her pistols. The rest of the team followed suit, to their surprise Adora pulled out a sword from her back. “For the honor of Grayskull!” Adora cried out and in a blinding flash, Adora became a ten foot tall warrior of light. Gareth and his team opened fire but Glimmer vanished in the blink of an eye, Bow took cover and Adora was simply not affected by the shots. Adora and Gareth clashed, with Gareth barely able to hold his ground. Glimmer warped in out of nowhere and spinkicked Catra into the dirt as Bow fired an EMP arrow that exploded and disabled the Team’s blasters.

Gareth was grabbed by the throat, feeling Adora's vice like grasp, and thrown into the ruined tank. Gareth felt the wind get knocked out of him. He gasped for air as his spine hurt like hell, Lonnie helped Gareth up "let's get the hell out of here!!" she yelled. Catra gazed at Adora in pure disbelief and Betrayal before vanishing with her allies into the burning smoke. Already beaten and definitely out matched by Adora's new form and her friends, the team retreated to the Fright Zone. Their Enemies, for whatever reason, decided not to pursue or attack any further. When they arrived, they would see that very few others actually returned. Operation breached was a 2,000 soldier operation and all that came back was 100, including Gareth and his team.

As her boyfriend was in the infirmary being treated for his broken ribs, and for once wasn't tortured by Hordak, Catra walked to the barracks and saw the little drawing she made of herself, Adora and Gareth on the wall between their beds. She clenched her fists until they began to bleed, in her sadness and rage she ripped up Adora's beds with her claws, crying the entire time. When this was done, Catra then clawed out the drawing of Adora. Once finished she fell to her knees and let out anguished sobs of pain, frustration and unfathomable levels of sadness.

Gareth blinked as he awoke on the infirmary bed, he looked around the room. Thanks to the crystal that was fused to his chest, he had gained incredible powers and regeneration was one of them. Gareth could feel his ribs getting better ever so slowly. He heard the gentle sounds of the medical equipment which lulled him back to sleep. Gareth felt his head rest on the pillow, as his eyes closed.

"Didn't think i'd ever see She-Ra again" A monstrous reptilian voice was heard in his head. "So that's She-ra, eh Apophis?"

Gareth lowly muttered, he wasn't sure if Shadow Weaver knew but the crystal had one other thing. It harboured a God Serpent named Apophis, who was one of the Lord of Creation. "Of course it was! 10 feet of brutish power! While I don't blame you for being unprepared, you must take her down!" Apophis hissed "but cheer up vessel, you'll get her next time." he then said teasingly as Gareth sighed and rubbed his forehead "yeah I guess I will" Gareth said as his wounds slowly healed ever so gently.

Gareth worried about Catra most of all however "how much longer till my ribs are put back together?" Gareth asked Apophis, he heard the snake chuckle "ah, not much longer now" Apophis said with a low hiss. Catra kept crying as she cuddled Gareth's blankets, trying to catch his scent to make her feel at ease. Catra's ears pricked up when she hears the door open, she slowly raises her head and sees Gareth standing in the doorway. Before he could get a word out of his mouth, Catra hugged him tightly and rested her ear against his chest. Catra heard Gareth's heartbeats, they were strong like a drum.

Catra sighed softly "Gareth please...don't leave me" she whispered softly, she felt Gareth's arms wrap around her. "I promised you I would always be by your side and I intend to keep it" he rested his chin on Catra's head as he glared at the scratched out face of Adora and he silently vowed that he would make her suffer…

Chapter 5: Plumera's Defense

Chapter 5

Plumera's Defense

This was to be an easy assignment, guard the manufacturing plants and make sure the Rebels don't interfere. Gareth and his team were deployed to the largest of these plants. Gareth could easily tell his team were still shaken up by the betrayal that was given out to them by Adora. He took a deep breath and maintained his composure "we still got each other guys, and i'll be damned if i'm gonna let anyone tear us apart." he said with a low growl

Scorpia nodded "y-yeah! We're a squad! A team! We need to stick together" she said nudging Kyle and winking to which the young blond offered a nervous smile as he held his Sniper close to his chest. Lonnie was busy loading energy cells into her laser shotgun, inspecting it so that it's in good shape. "I can't wait to blast some holes in anyone who tries to pull any shit with us!" she said with a cocky grin.

Catra nodded and cocked her pistols "damn straight!" she said with a giggle as Gareth simply chuckled and sharpened his axe slowly. At least he can take into consideration that this time they won't be ambushed while in the tanks. Gareth sighed and rested his head on the wall as the tank rhythmically drove forward. Eventually, the tank arrived at its destination. Gareth and his team stepped out and gazed at the situation. The power plant hummed gently, it too was belching out smoke. Kyle noticed how grey and lifeless the ground was and Gareth simply nudged a plant with his foot and watched it crumble into dust.

“Damn, looks like this place is dying.” Gareth said as he crouched down to examine a plant that was also slowly dying. “Heh, who knows, maybe in a decade or so we could just waltz right into Brightmoon” Gareth said with a chuckle as he stood up

“Well we can only hope it's a lot sooner than that” Catra said as she gazed at the forest. “How come the Plumerans just let us build here? It doesn’t make a lot of sense” Catra pondered as she crossed her arms and gazed upon the old withering trees which looked like they weren’t that far away from crumbling into dust.

“I dunno, I heard that the Plumerans are pacifists. Maybe that’s why?” Kyle said with a shrug as he was checking out the facility for a good sniper position. “Paci-what?” Scorpia said with a raised eyebrow and a tilt of her head, Kyle smiled a little and blushed “ya know...pacifists. They don’t like fighting” he said with a soft chuckle.

“Well in that case, why haven’t we just crushed them?” Gareth asked with a scoff, leaning against one of the tanks. “Well Gareth, you barbaric axe-lover” Lonnie began with a teasing tone of voice and a giggle “it’s cuz the Plumerans pretty much rule the forests, their princess can control plants and stuff. Thaaaaaaaaaaaat and they are extremely close friends of Brightmoon” Lonnie explained to Gareth “I thought you read up on the plumerans before you got here?” she asked him

Gareth rubbed the back of his neck and had a sheepish grin “yeaaaaaaaaaaaahhh...about that” he chuckled a bit nervously to which Lonnie simply rolled her eyes. Catra walked around when she noticed 3 soldiers that were acting odd.

She walked up to them “hey! You!" The 3 soldiers stood in place before turning around. “The hell are you guys doing? You’re supposed to be guarding the rear gate!” Catra hissed as the soldiers exchanged glances. “S-sorry miss! We-we were uhm...uhhh…” the 2nd soldier was trying to hide his voice as he spoke, but it was that distinctive *voice crack* that allowed her to identify who it was. Catra delivered a brutal claw swipe, removing the helmet from this imposter.

The imposter was none other than Bow, Adora’s friend. The other two imposters were Adora and Glimmer. Catra smirked “hey Adora” she said before she backflipped away from a sword swipe from Adora. Catra wrapped her claws around the alarm switch and pulled it.

The blaring alarms were more than enough to get the station on full alert. Gareth rushed into the facility with his axe, being followed by Lonnie with her shotgun. Kyle turned around in his sniper nest, locked sights on Adora, now in her She-Ra form, and pulled the trigger.

Adora cried out as her shoulder unleashed an arterial spurt of blood as the bullet cleaved through her shoulder, but her body healed rather quickly. She looked up at Kyle, only for Gareth to slam her into a wall. “Gotcha!!” Gareth yelled angrily before bringing down his axe on her.

Adora was barely able to dodge the axe blow as it cleaved through the concrete and steel floor of the facility. Lonnie kept firing her shotgun at Glimmer but Glimmer kept teleporting around and delivering punches on Lonnie. Catra kept dodging arrows being fired at her by Bow until she grabbed an arrow out of mid air, lunged forward and drove the arrow into Bow’s

shoulder, causing a splash of warm blood to cover Catra's face as she then delivers a brutal kick that knocks the rebel archer back. She smirked and grinned with glee as she flicked the blood off her furry hand. "Nice try arrow boy" she said with a cruel grin.

Gareth was knocked back by Adora and caught the sword of protection in his hand, the blade cut into his hand and caused it to bleed ever so slightly. He gritted his teeth through the pain and looked up at Adora with a hateful glare before headbutting her in the gutt and sending her to the ground. "You are annoying Sis...you really are" he growled before rolling his neck and raising up his axe. It was then large vines emerged from the ground and began to attack the Horde soldiers which of course, caused panic amongst the ranks. Gareth growled angrily as a bunch of Plumerans began charging out of the forest.

"Well looks like you're outnumbered" Adora said with a smirk. "Horde. fucking. dammit." Gareth said facepalming himself "well played sis. But this is war, and in war people die." Gareth said with a cruel grin. "MEN! WOMEN! OPEN FIRE!!" he roared as the Horde soldiers began to shoot their laser weapons into the ground, which ripped through them with ease. The turrets did a lot of the damage however.

Adora punched Gareth into a wall, she was about to pummel him into a pulp when Bow caused the Facility's main reactor to blow, which powered down the turrets. "FUCK!" Lonnie yelled as she began to run, Kyle and Rogelio followed suit.

Gareth headbutted Adora on the nose, he could hear a crunch when he did so and he then began to run. "MOVE IT PEOPLE! GET TO THE TANKS!" he yelled. He then saw a Horde soldier trip and fall, a vengeful Plumeran was about to crack her skull and helmet open with a warclub.

Gareth ran up and cleaved the plumeran in half, splattering blood all over himself and the Horde Soldier. He grabbed the soldier by the hand and began to run to the tanks. Arrows whizzed by his head “come on soldier! I’m not leaving you behind!” he said with a growl, much to the soldier’s shock.

Catra watched as the arrows flew at Gareth and the soldier, she desperately made sure there was enough room for them both. Gareth and the soldier clambered into the Tank as it began to surge forward. Gareth panted and took a seat. The Horde Soldier took off her helmet, revealing a tan Etherian with brown eyes and a half cut hairstyle that was black in coloration. “Y-you saved me...you could’ve died there.” she said

Catra shuddered and cuddled Gareth tightly “that’s Gareth for ya” she said, checking to see if Gareth got hurt. “I don’t leave anyone behind.” Gareth said with a sigh. “Well we failed…” Scorpia muttered, The trio looked over to Gareth with concerned looks. Gareth sighed as he knew what it meant, a personal visit to Hordak...and not the fun kind.

Gareth was going to be punished, as it has always been. Gareth shuddered as he mentally prepared himself for what will occur, the pain that he will no doubt endure.

Chapter 6: Punishment

Chapter 6

Punishment

Shadow Weaver watched as the tanks began to roll in from a balcony. She could see soldiers walking up to the tanks and the group of surviving people from the ruined Plumeran operation. She mentally counted down to Catra's defiant calls, Catra constantly called out against this punishment of Gareth but of course she was ignored. From here, Shadow Weaver could see the confusion on Scorpia's face, she could tell that Scorpia was trying to put a solid case for Gareth...but they were, of course, ignored.

Gareth was handcuffed and brought inside, Shadow Weaver could see him look up at her. She turned around and headed back inside. This had been going on for years, ever since he was a teenager. Gareth was always a defiant soul and he had paid for that dearly, if the nasty scar on his nose wasn't evidence enough.

But there was once an incident that truly sealed his fate in the eyes of Hordak. It happened after a rather violent fight between Gareth and Adora back when they were teenagers, Shadow Weaver had been training Adora to become an excellent commander...she had her reasons as to why. But Gareth didn't like how Adora's ego had grown way out of proportions and thus the two ended up brawling.

That night, a rebellion dagger was found under Gareth's pillow. How it had gotten from the confiscated weapons armory all the

way to the barracks is unknown but there certainly was no way Gareth could have snuck it up there, given his inability for stealth. Shadow Weaver knew it was planted but she couldn't figure out who planted it there and framed Gareth.

Regardless, ever since Gareth was framed, he was tortured for every major failure he did. Often his screams would echo throughout the Fright Zone, it brought terrible stress to his friends and Shadow Weaver could barely stand to hear it herself. She did care for all three of her children, even though she had little experience being a mother and her disciplinary actions were more than severe. Oftentimes she wonders if she went too far in her actions. Shadow Weaver let out a troubled sigh before she warped into her chambers, and prepared herself mentally for the inevitable screams of her son.

Gareth was escorted into a dimly lit room, where the only light came from the warm heat of one of the Fright zone's many reactors which was just underneath his feet. Giving the metal grated floor not only an ominous orange glow, like one walked into the boiler room of hell, but it made it very warm to the touch. Gareth was stripped of his clothes, leaving nothing but his undergarments and he was shackled to the ceiling, causing him to hang just a few inches off the ground. Gareth took in a deep breath and exhaled as he heard Hordak enter the room.

"Incompetent as always Gareth. Even after I gave you the rank of Force Captain" Hordak snarled cruelly as he prepared some bladed instruments by heating them up. Gareth simply scoffed as he glared forward "yeah yeah, whatever fucker" he said before Hordak slashed his back, causing him to cry out in pain. "How dare you speak back to me!" Hordak hissed as Gareth felt the warmth of his own blood flow down his back. "You defiant beast!"

he snarled before slashing up Gareth’s back some more, Gareth’s cries of anguish rattled across the Fright Zone. The buds of tears formed in the corner of his eyes, his crystal glowed and his wounds slowly healed but Hordak simply kept slashing into him.

After a few minutes of suffering, Gareth snarled defiantly. "You...are a fucking coward Hordak" Gareth snarl echoed through the air as Hordak looked upon him with utter hatred. "what did you say?" Hordak said with a hiss of seething rage. "A true leader, is one who leads by the front. a person of strength is the only true leader, you are a coward. making us fight but never fighting with us, you simply bark from your throne like you are some fucking god. but you are *NOT*. you're just a mortal, like me...but the difference between me and you is that I am stronger than you in every conceivable way" Gareth said, looking into Hordak's soul with his emerald eyes.

Hordak's wrath came in the fury of broken bones and bloodied wounds. Gareth's cries of agony were heard, but never once did he beg for forgiveness. Gareth was defiant as ever, even as Catra covered her ears and wept as Gareth’s cries of pain were heard even in the barracks. Scorpia stayed next to her, trying to comfort her without hugging her. Eventually Gareth was dragged towards the infirmary by two soldiers, leaving a trail of blood. Catra cursed Adora the entire time that Gareth spent recovering.

Chapter 7: Hell On The High Seas

Chapter 7

Hell on the High Seas

The moment Gareth was out of the infirmary, Hordak had him and his team deployed to Salineas. Intel suggests that their famous shield wall is finally fading which means a perfect opportunity to strike. As the team prepped up, Gareth approached Catra and kissed her furry cheek. “Hey, you okay?” he asked with a comforting smile as he wrapped his arms around her.

Catra blushed a little and looked down. “You know me and water don’t mix” she said, wrapping her hands around his own hands and giving them a gentle squeeze. Gareth simply smiled and nuzzled his girlfriend’s cheek “yeah I know” he said softly into her ear which caused her feline ears to bounce up and down. Catra giggled and purred gently as she reached behind him and stroked his chin. Lonnie approached the two, carrying a crate of supplies. Upon seeing how they’re up to their usual lovey dovey antics, Lonnie rolled her eyes playfully “alright you two, come on. We got a ship to board.” she said as she walked past them.

Catra and Gareth nodded, making their way towards the docks of the Fright Zone. There a large horde corvette was waiting for them, Gareth saw a small squad of soldiers that were also boarding. One of them approached Gareth and Catra, giving them a salute. “Force Captains, me and my soldiers are at your disposal!” the soldier said in a professional tone of voice, one you might expect from a soldier who has been drilled into service his entire life. Gareth smiled and simply waved his hand “At ease,

soldier, we're not all about that professional shit. Just make sure the ship is ready for departure"

The soldier nodded and gathered his team, making sure the ship was prepped for departure. Scorpia was more than excited to be up on a boat, she had packed a bunch of snacks...which were all ration bars. "Scorps, uhhh, did you have to pack so many ration bars?" Gareth said with a sigh. Scorpia nodded "I sure did! It's gonna be amazing, us on the high seas!" she eagerly pondered, imagining the high seas to be something amazing.

Gareth chuckled "alright, alright" he said before he walked up to the captain's wheel, seeing a soldier was at the helm. He smiled softly before looking forward. "Helmsman, take us to Salineas" he said with a low grin

The Helmsman nodded and began to drive the corvette out of the dock, making a thunderous splash as it left the harbour. Soon they were out and about on the open seas, heading towards Salineas.

A few days of uneventful sailing and sea shanties, they were gazing upon the gates of Salineas, the shield wall was still up albeit it is riddled with holes. Catra is looking at the wall through a spyglass, her brow furrowed in confusion. "Shadow Weaver isn't gonna be happy about this," Catra said with a low growl of frustration.

"She rarely is" Gareth sighed and rubbed his temple, Gareth looked over at the helmsman "send a call out to-", Gareth was cut off as a round of cannon fire impacted the ship, punching a few holes in the lower decks.

Kyle froze as a cannonball went barrelling towards her head, Scorpia tackled Kyle to the ground, saving his life. "I got you! I got you!" Scorpia muttered as she hugged him. Gareth looked up

and could see a Salineas warship, identifiable by its iconic blue stained wood, coming at them at full speeds. It rammed into their ship and rebel soldiers began to pour out, Horde and Rebel soldiers began to engage each other on the Corvette's metal hull, blood spilling onto its black metal.

Among the rebels was Mermista and several Salineas soldiers, a strange mustached individual was among them, but that's barely noteworthy given the crazed conflict.

Gareth growled and grabbed his axe, charging forward at a familiar archer. Bow barely dodged Gareth's crazed axe swing, letting out a panicked voice crack as the axe swung through the air.

"Get off my ship!" Gareth yelled before Adora dived in as She-Ra and kicked him to the floor with great force. Gareth winced in pain as he felt a rib crack, his crystal already began to heal the damage. Adora glared at him "You're not taking Salineas Gareth " she said defiantly. Gareth rolled his shoulder and paced a bit. "Yeah? I'm not gonna listen to a traitor, in fact, I'm going to end one!" he roared before dropping his axe and tackling Adora. He had misjudged how much floor was behind Adora, as they both took a dive into the ocean.

Gareth opened his eyes and could see the very air from the water was being sucked into his mouth, effectively giving him the ability to breathe underwater. The familiar golden glow from his crystal indicated that this ability was Apophis' doing, he shook his head and could see that Adora was trying to swim to the surface.

A dark opportunity gleamed in his eyes and he grabbed Adora's leg and dragged her close. He locked his forearms around Adora's

head, with his left forearm pressing firmly against her throat and the right making sure her head kept firmly still. He was choking her, Gareth's heart beat became quicker and quicker as he kept Adora in place, she tried kicking at him but Gareth rammed his knee into her back a few times

Adora let out a scream that only served to deprive her of the only remaining oxygen she had left and filled her lung with water. Eventually, she stopped moving and her eyes went blank.

Gareth let her go, and slowly watched her body tumble lifelessly into the dark depths below. He managed to snag the fabled sword of protection from Adora as she sank into the depths. Gareth swam up and broke the surface, he took notice of the fighting and made it onto the deck. Everyone stopped fighting as Gareth panted, soaked in seawater. He tossed She-Ra's sword onto the deck, where it clattered onto the metal floor.

"Game. Over." Gareth snarled with a sadistic grin.

Chapter 8: She-Ra's Cruelty

Chapter 8

She-Ra's Cruelty

Even the Horde soldiers were stunned by this feat. Catra was mentally processing this as she stared at the seawater drenched blade. 'Gareth really did it? Adora's Dead?' were just a couple of the thoughts running through her head.

Scorpia was going to say something until a grief-stricken wail broke the tension-fused silence. That wail came from Glimmer, who warped up to Gareth and began to beat on him relentlessly, but her efforts were in vain as she only got a few punches in before Gareth caught her fists and growled. "That's enough of that" Gareth growled before tossing her down.

"Your She-Ra's dead and gone, so why don't you Rebels surrender?" Gareth said with a glare, each of the Salineas soldiers began to toss down their weapons as Gareth simply smirked. Glimmer and the rebels however, did not. They took full advantage of the standstill to lash out at the enemy, being caught off guard already causing a few casualties among the horde.

Glimmer went back to lashing out at Gareth, teleporting all over the place to punch him repeatedly and making any effort to combat her an extremely difficult task. Bow knocked arrow after arrow, firing them with such speed that he might as well be a machine gun. The mustached individual did try to fight but found himself swiftly disarmed and was soon backing into a wall. Mermista saved this individual's life by knocking them down with a wave of seawater. Scorpia punched a soldier down before they

were able to kill Kyle. “Come on Kyle! Keep at it!” Lonnie said, using her shotgun on several of these soldiers.

“Murderer! Monster! Barbarian!! You killed her!! You **killed her!!!** ” Glimmer yelled in a frenzy, constantly wailing on Gareth. It wasn’t until Gareth managed to backhand her into the ground “I had to! It was either me or her!” he said, grabbing his axe and lifting it from the ground.

Glimmer was angrily spitting words as sadness choked her. She stood up and readied some more magic. “She cared about you!! About you and Catra!!” Glimmer yelled at him but Gareth shook his head. “She wouldn’t have abandoned me and Catra if she did” He said before lifting the axe over his head, ready to cleave Glimmer vertically. That’s when the Sword of Protection began to clatter on the ground wildly, catching Gareth and Glimmer’s Attention. It then flew up in the air and dove down into the depths. Mere moments later Adora leaped from the water and onto the deck with a loud thud. Adora’s eyes were pure white and she spat a whole bunch of seawater from her mouth.

Adora didn’t say a thing as she lunged forward and stabbed Gareth in the gut, causing him to cry out in shock. Adora ripped the sword out, spraying Gareth’s blood all over the deck before she delivered a brutal punch that sent him flying across the deck and past everyone. Adora slaughtered anyone who tried to interfere, Horde soldiers were flung aside like ragdolls and their blood went everywhere. Even the Rebel soldiers began to tell her to calm down but nothing seemed to. It was as if a malevolent force had taken her.

“ *Your crimes are many Apophis, to once think I served you* ” Adora spoke in a voice that wasn’t her own. Gareth could feel a

dark force steal his ability to speak, Apophis began to talk through Gareth. " *Ah, Aria, one of my more vigilant She-Ras. I didn't realize you'd be the one to save Adora's life* " Apophis spoke through Gareth like a puppet. Gareth hated the sensation, but he wasn't going to enjoy what was gonna come next.

Without another word, Adora...or whatever had taken over her body, began to brutally beat down on Gareth. Gareth could barely comprehend what was happening as he was tossed around like a ragdoll and his body was in such pain that it began to feel overwhelmingly numb. Gareth could barely hear everyone's panic, especially Catra's screams. He couldn't see what was going on after a minute into the beating, Gareth was blinded by his own blood spilling over his eyes. Soon he blacked out, feeling icy cold...despite the warmth of his own blood covering him.

The last thing he heard was Catra screaming his name...

Chapter 9: Wake Up Call

Chapter 9

Wake Up Call

Gareth woke up in the infirmary, he gently heard the beeping of the medical machines go off in their rhythmic patterns. Gareth sat up and groggily looked around the room, he could see a nurse typing away on a terminal in the room up ahead.

He rubbed his eyes before gently removing the IV from his hand, watching the small pin prick needle wound his hand heal up in less than a minute. Gareth swung his legs to the side of the bed and got off, walking towards the nurse and rubbing the back of his neck. How long had he been out? His neck was sore as hell, so it must've been a week.

"Excuse me nurse?" Gareth said, the nurse nearly jumped out of her chair. Fumbling over and falling down as she did so. "W-w-what the!?!?" she yelped, scrambling over her words. All of this brought a surprise to Gareth who wasn't used to this.

The Nurse scrambled up and bolted down the hall, ramming into the Infirmary head by accident. "D-Doctor!? H-he's-" she stammered like a lunatic as Doctor Mantenna stood there in shock. Mantenna was an oddity, even by Horde Standards. Apparently he came from the more foreign reaches of Etheria. Parts of which he didn't say nor is willing to discuss, regardless, this frog-like person whose red and blue skin contrasted highly with his bulbous yellow eyes, is an extremely skilled doctor.

But even he was dumbfounded by the sight of Gareth just standing there. “Y-You’re awake!? And Standing!?” he exclaimed in pure awe. Gareth was confused “uhm...why wouldn’t I be?” Gareth said with a tilted head “You’ve been out for a month! A-and your injuries?! You should be crippled from the neck down for life!!” Mantenna exclaimed, clutching his clipboard to his body as if it would protect him from the sight he was seeing.

“A MONTH?!” Gareth yelled which caused Mantenna and the nurse to back up in surprise. Mantenna stammered “y-yes! M-mr. Elinas, c-can you please sit down and we’ll run some tests!” he said, trying to put his beside mannerisms to use but Gareth ran past them.

Gareth refused to believe it was a month, he couldn’t, he didn’t want to believe it! Gareth had never ran as fast as he did right now. Soon he was at the doorway of the Barracks. He stopped and was panting hard, he looked up to see his team’s surprised faces.

“B-boss?” Scorpia said with eyes the size of dinner plates. Gareth was going to respond but he was tackled to the ground by Catra, who showered him in kisses and cuddles. Gareth looked at his girlfriend, who was crying tears of pure joy.

“I-I thought I lost you forever!” Catra wept into his arms and held him close. Gareth cried silently as he hugged Catra, burying his face into her soft mane. After a few moments like that Catra and Gareth stood up. Gareth sat down in front of the group, still in a medical gown. Lonnie got up “uhm, i’ll go grab your clothes” she said before walking out of the room. Kyle still couldn’t believe what was happening “I don’t know how you’re up and about but...but you are!” he exclaimed with a smile.

Gareth nodded “yeah, not sure how i’m doing it either, but i’m not complaining” he said with a soft chuckle. “How’d I even get back here?” he asked.

Scorpia cleared her throat and began to explain “well uhm, yeah. Glimmer managed to calm Adora down from her possession. We immediately called a truce and retreated. It took all of our medical supplies to keep you alive!” Gareth rubbed the back of his head “you guys didn’t get in trouble?” he asked, to which Catra looked down a bit. “No, I got the verbal lashing of my life from Weaver and Hordak.” she said, rubbing her furry shoulder.

Gareth sighed and patted her back “well i’m back, and I promise you that i’m not gonna go down like that again.” he said, trying to be comforting. “Next time Adora pulls that shit, we’re going to kick her ass!” Catra yelled, a month’s worth of suppressing rage coming out in a single loud sentence. The rest of the team nodded in agreement. “No one hurts the boss and gets away with it!” Kyle said with a determined grin. Rogelio growled out a response and Scorpia nodded as well. Lonnie grinned and leaned on the door way “damn straight, also your clothes are on their way” she said before walking towards the group and sitting down.

“Right! Let’s get back out there!” Gareth said standing up, Catra shook her head and gently pressed on Gareth’s shoulder. Gareth sat down in response “noooooo, *first* you are going to take a shower. You smell!” Catra said teasingly.

Chapter 10: Operation Dryl

Chapter 10

Operation: Dryll

Dryll, The Ghost Kingdom also known as the dead kingdom. Dryll was once the most technologically advanced kingdom out there, having become so due to the royal family's obsession with First Ones tech. Dryll was also the first victim of the Horde; it's said that during Hordak's early years, he ordered the kingdom to be raided for supplies. These supplies would be the technology that Dryll would have been perfecting, and would ultimately fuel the creation of the Fright Zone. Among the casualties would be the King and Queen of Dryll.

But, as it turns out from a recently captured rebel prisoner, The princess of Dryll, known as Entrapta is alive. Whoever gets Entrapta on their side will no doubt have the ultimate advantage in this war. So of course, Gareth and his team were deployed. Along with a platoon of soldiers. Gareth and his team were prepared to convince Entrapta to come along...what they weren't prepared for was an armada of crazed and bloodthirsty robots.

"Go to Dryll, they said! It will be easy, they said! Easy my fucking ass!!" Gareth yelled as Catra clinged onto his back for dear life. Scorpia was holding onto Kyle as Rogelio carried Lonnie. "Don't stop running!" Catra yelled, unintentionally sinking her claws into Gareth's shoulders, which did cause Gareth some pain. Gareth saw a door up ahead and rammed it open, everyone including the remaining soldiers ran inside the room and slammed it shut. "Barricade the door now!!" Gareth yelled as he and Catra pushed a large metal crate and propped it against the door.

The rest of the team followed suit. Propping all that they could find against the heavy metal doors. Catra slowly got off Gareth's back as everyone catched their breath. "Sir, this is fucking FUBAR" one of the Soldiers said to Gareth, to which he nodded. "Y-yeah...holy shit yeah…" Gareth replied and rolled his neck, trying to calm his beating heart. "No sign of Entrapta, all of what we've seen are monstrous robots!" Lonnie said "and I only have a few rounds left!" she said counting the rounds she had for her laser shotgun. "Make a count of all the ammo, see if there's anything we can salvage here" Gareth said

The group spread out, finding out that the room they were in is actually a massive warehouse. Filled with all kinds of junk that they could find a way to put together. "Say Boss, I know you got a hobby for designing stuff. What with that little journal of yours" Kyle said with a smile "maybe you can whip something up?" he asked with a hopeful gleam in his eyes. "Designing stuff is one thing, it's a whole other ballpark for actually making stuff" Gareth explained.

"You did design a mask that would deprive the wearer of sleep like...forever" Catra said "as long as they would wear it" she said with a shrug. Scorpia blinked and looked at Gareth "y-you did??" she said in a bit of a shocked surprise. Gareth nodded "yep! It would be a great torture device, making the person delirious with no sleep at all" he said with a chuckle. "Yooooou can be a little messed up sometimes Boss, Not. Gonna. Lie." Lonnie said, carrying a box of equipment.

She lost her balance and landed on the wall, her elbow pressing a button. A large section of wall, or what they thought was a wall at first, opened up to reveal a large workshop and in it was Entrapta...and the Rebels.

Chapter 11: Co-Operative Means

Chapter 11

Co-Operative Means

Everyone lined up, Glimmer with her magic, Bow with his arrows, that mustached figure with his cutlass and Adora…"Oh...my Horde" Gareth said with his jaw agape and Catra couldn't believe her eyes. It was the legendary drunk adora!

"heeeeeeeyyy...Garreeeeeeeyy! Cattreeey! Wh-what'sh shup?" Adora slurred as she drunkenly leaned on her blade with a half dazed look on her face. Ever since Gareth, Catra and Adora earned access to mead rations in the horde, drunk adora became a legend...or a meme depending on how you saw it. Adora's lightweight disposition to alcohol was medically fascinating, Doctor Mantenna even called it 'A fucking anomaly'. So much as a sip of even the lightest of beers can get Adora into a drunken stupor that would put even hardcore alcoholics to shame.

"Wh-...why is Adora drunk?!" Gareth said with more confusion than anything else. Before Glimmer could respond, Entrapta stood up and smiled. "Oh! It's an First Ones designed virus, it infected her sword!" Entrapta said excitedly, sparkled in her eyes. "It's so fascinating isn't it?!" Entrapta said. Glimmer pinched the bridge of her nose. "Yes yes, well we're trapped on all sides by a bunch of murderbots! And now we have to deal with you guys!" Glimmer growled. Gareth sighed "no, it would be stupid to try and do that. I guess we need to work together." he said with a sigh. "Well good luck with that, I'm almost out of arrows!" Bow said with a scoff

“We’re almost out of ammo!” Catra hissed angrily. Entrapta didn’t like where this was going but Gareth stepped in between them both. “We got PLENTY of resources, we just need to put them to use.” Gareth said looking at Entrapta “I can design some weapons, can you make those designs into a reality?” he asked her Entrapta’s eyes glowed like fireworks “You mean...collaborate!” she said with a squee of excitement. Gareth nodded “you got a place where I can design?” he asked which Entrapta excitedly nodded and led him over to a designing table. “You design! I’ll build it! Let’s do this!” Entrapta said with pure joy.

While this was happening Catra and Glimmer locked eyes. “I guess we gotta figure out a plan. You got some intel of what we need to take out to make these robots stop?” Catra then leaned in with her arms crossed and squinted her eyes “Sparkles?” she said, making sure Glimmer heard every syllable of that word. Glimmer nodded “damn right I do” she said, but before she can explain Adora leaned up against Glimmer and pressed her face into her backside.

“My thiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiicc cuppycaaaaaaaaaake” Adora drunkenly muttered and giggled softly. Glimmer’s face turned redder than a ruby as Catra had a look that was so smug it took the book of smarm and snapped its back like a twig. “Seahawk.” Glimmer muttered, to which Seahawk walked up to Glimmer. “Y-yes?” Seahawk said with a raised eyebrow. “K-Keep an eye on Adora. Please?” Glimmer said, about to annihilate *several* gaskets.

Catra leaned back and stroked her chin “damn, I don’t know whether to call you sparkles or cuppycake” she said, trying to suppress a snicker. Glimmer growled and explained the plan. The robots were being powered by a massive generator at the heart of

the kingdom, they take out the First Ones power gem, they take out the robots.

Everyone locked and loaded with their new shrapnel guns, or as Gareth called them 'bullet guns', kicked down the door and began blasting their way through. Scorpia and Seahawk were on babysitting duty the whole time though, but they didn't mind it.

After the battle was done and the robots were taken care of. There was one thing left...who was Entrapta going to join? Entrapta approached Gareth and gave him a hug "Gareth, you're a great designer! Buuuut…" Entrapta let go of Gareth and looked over at the Rebels. "My heart tells me that I should go with them." Adora and the others readied themselves for a fight but Gareth smiled. "Alright, I guess we'll see you around." Gareth said, surprising both the horde and the rebels. "Sure! … oh!" Entrapta gave Gareth the designs he himself made. "You keep them, a token of what we worked on" she said happily. Gareth nodded "sure thing." he happily said before walking off.

Sure they didn't win but...Gareth felt like he just made a genuine friend. He doesn't have any of those outside of his team.

Chapter 12: My Will Be Done

Chapter 12

My Will Be Done

Apophis stretched his golden limbs, his regal claws scratched the inky black stones that formed his ancient realm. The Realm of Apophis was full of black storms and islands of ancient black stone, all the souls of those who served him wander these islands, adhering to his primordial will.

Apophis flew in these dark skies, his eyes watching over all of this ancient domain. A cruel smirk crawled over his maw as he gazed upon the billions of First Ones souls that wander aimlessly. His siblings gave him Etheria, all who lived on it were his playthings. The God Serpents, the lords of creation who made all of reality, had used the First Ones as their slaves for thousands of years. Indeed, the Sword of Protection was more akin to a shackle. To enslave She-Ra to the will of the God Serpents, but ultimately, to enslave She-Ra to *his will* .

All from their crystalline prisons, they ruled the Universe for millions of years. Now? Now Apophis was fused to a mere mortal...he was fused to Gareth. His only window to the world outside of his realm, was the shard of his crystal and it was often covered by a shirt or damn armor. It was nothing short of heresy for a God Serpent to be shackled to a mortal. They destroyed worlds and forced entire species to slaughter each other just for their entertainment! They slaughtered the Titan and forged the Boiling Isles from his corpse! The primitive natives of Amphibia had them to thank for their glorious robotics and forging their near utopian society! Alteans and Galra were terrified of ever crossing them!

They were the sons and daughters of Ames! These lesser races should be thanking them that they allowed them to even discover fire in the first place! Apophis snarled as the skies of his realm crackled with golden lightning, the subservient souls of the realm began to pray to him and beg him to not annihilate them in a fit of rage. Their pathetic begging was enough to calm Apophis, he grinned as he already began to formulate a new plan. His host was a capable servant, but also easy to influence. Posing as his friend was enough to get the love-starved barbarian to listen to whatever he had planned.

That and that Thunderian woman was already making it so easy to influence the human all the more. Apophis slithered through the skies of his realm and towards a massive golden pillar. Apophis sunk his six claws into it and slithered up until he reached the top. He grinned as he began to plot his next move. Apophis' tongue slithered out of his mouth as he began to contemplate. The fact is that, His host's current position as a Force Captain is NOT going to cut it. He needed the plan to overthrow Hordak to be successful, but to do that he had to ensure that this barbarian could actually achieve that goal in the first place.

His host needs to move up the chain of command however, and Apophis knew just what he needed his host to do...

Chapter 13: Sacking Of Mystacor

Chapter 13

Sacking of Mystacor

Gareth walked up the steps towards the main operations room where Hordak and Shadow Weaver were planning the horde's next move. It has been months since Operation Breach and every mission thus far has been nothing short of disastrous. 6 months of She-Ra ripping apart horde operations with ease. Fights across Etheria and even the attempt to recruit Entrapta had resulted in nothing short of defeat. Gareth has suffered horrid tortures by Hordak for each and every failure and the War was turning towards the Rebellion's favour. Something needed to be done and soon.

"Hordak, please...if you will let me summon my spies and-" Shadow Weaver tried to explain her plan but once again Hordak was unwilling to listen. Out of frustration Hordak slammed his fist down onto the war table, causing the holographic map of Etheria to glitch out "I do not need your spies! I need results!" Hordak snarled angrily. Gareth stood at attention before Hordak locked his gaze onto him. "Yes Force Captain" Hordak growled, his tone made it clear to Gareth that every letter was drenched in disdain for the young force captain. "Lord Hordak, I have a suggestion for our next course of action" Gareth started, Hordak maintained his gaze upon Gareth.

"I suggest that we sack Mystacor and grab many, if not all, of its magical artifacts" Gareth said with an aura of pride. Shadow Weaver grew an aura of anger around her in response to this, her body flowed with darkness along with the shadows around her. "How dare you suggest such a thing!" she hissed to Gareth, who

stood at attention, not even flinching. Both were surprised by Hordak chuckling, they looked at him. He was stroking his chin "stealing the Rebellion's magical stockpile and take it for our own? A far superior, and bolder, plan than Shadow Weaver's mere shadowy spies!" Hordak declared with a grin as Shadow Weaver stood there in shock.

Gareth grinned excitedly "soooo...is that a yes Lord Hordak?" Gareth asked leaning forward as he asked the question to which Hordak nodded "yes it is, Force Captain Gareth. You will have the adequate forces and equipment necessary, For once you show promise! Dismissed!" Hordak said, Gareth walked away leaving behind a shocked Shadow Weaver and a Hordak who was eager for a victory, no matter how small, against She-Ra. A couple of days Later, Gareth and Catra made their way with a large army to Mystacor. After some careful traversal of the environment they soon gazed upon the floating City, Gareth smiled as he placed down his axe by his side.

"Scorps? Roll out the bridge! We're crashing this party!" Gareth said with a giddy grin. Scorpia saluted him "Yes Boss!" she said before she pointed at Mystacor, the specialized harpoon tanks opened fire, the large chains deployed hard light bridges as soon as the harpoons dug into Mystacor. Catra grinned and pointed forward with her hand on her hip. "Charge!!" Catra yelled as the Horde forces charged on the bridges. The defenders of Mystacor were caught off guard as they were gunned down by the horde.

Gareth hewn a mage in half with his Greataxe as Catra slashes another's throat open with her claws. "Keep going! Into the Vaults!" Gareth roared, extended his hand out and blasted more defenders with Golden lightning. Catra broke into the hot springs and saw Adora and her friends in the Hot Springs, they were

completely off guard. Catra was accompanied by Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio. "Hey Adora" Catra said teasingly and with a cocky smirk.

Before Adora and her friends could respond, The Trio opened fire. Adora leaped out of the hot spring and took cover. Bow nocked an arrow and fired it at Catra to which she caught it "yeah that ain't gonna work" Catra coyly remarked, Bow smirked in response "give it a moment Catra" he shouted from behind cover.Catra saw a small light on the arrow lit up "...is this armed??" she said before the arrow exploded like a flashbang in her face, causing Catra some disorientation. Glimmer clenched her fists and teleported towards the gear she and her friends left and grabbed Adora's Sword just as she saw Rogelio aim his gatling laser at her and open fire.

"Holy Shit!" Glimmer cried out before teleporting to cover. While Catra and the trio kept Adora and her friends occupied, Gareth and Scorpia ensured that the riches of mystacor were secured. Gareth gazed up at the statue of a veiled figure, he innately recognized who it was. "So this is why you had such reservations against me doing this...you came from here mom" he mused, not even bothering to correct himself for referring to Shadow Weaver with that title. Gareth heard footsteps behind him, he looked over his shoulder to see Castaspella, charging a spell to use on him. "Light Spinner lives?" she asked to which Gareth rolled his shoulder and turned towards her. "She goes by Shadow Weaver these days. But I got a friend who you should worry about more" Gareth said approaching her, which caused her to tense up.

"Who would that be?" Casta said as Gareth closed his eyes. When Gareth opened his eyes, they were golden " *Apophis* " Gareth said in the God Serpent's voice before blasting Casta with a blast of golden lightning straight from his mouth, the blast sent Casta flying back and into a wall, knocking her out. Gareth then proceeded into one of the artifact rooms of Mystacor where he

gazed upon a variety of non magical jewelry. Gareth's eyes locked onto a ring with the sigil of a four horned skull, he pocketed the ring for himself before rushing outside with his fellow Horde Soldiers and his team.

"Soldiers! We are leaving!" Gareth ordered as he got into an APC with Catra, Scorpia and the Trio. The APC roared to life as they made their escape with the many treasures of Mystacor loaded onto their APCs. The trip was quiet, the many forces made their way home in silence. Gareth sung a tune "There was a brave Cadet and he held his rifle high" Gareth began "He followed every command as if his end was nigh" Catra joined in with a low smirk, Scorpia enthusiastically sung along "he stood his ground as the artillery roared!" She sang freely before the trio joined in "and he ain't gonna shoot no more!" they all sang together. Soon the entire battalion was in a chorus as they made it back home, basking in victory.

Chapter 14: Love In The Storm

Chapter 14

Love in the Storm

Historically, The lands of the Fright Zone were hostile and desert like, but ever since the day Gareth was fused with his crystal so many long years ago, constant thunderstorms with pouring rain had occurred so much that it became the norm. In many cases, it caused the Fright Zone to have an even more imposing visage. This day was no different, as the many denizens of The Fright Zone did their business. Soldiers doing Patrols and Engineers ensuring the maintenance of the Fright Zone, one soul was standing before a window gazing out into the vast industrial kingdom.

Gareth watched as the thunder echoed in the distance, After his extreme success with commanding forces and taking the treasures of Mystacor, he gained a very special promotion. Gareth looked at the green and white badge in his hand, it was shimmering slightly as the emblem was untouched and very clean. It looked like it hadn't even seen the light of day until hordak pulled it out to give it to him. Gareth had been given a Rank that places him as a member of Hordak's inner circle, making Shadow Weaver his peer and equal in rank. He was a Force Commander now, Gareth had already been using his new found rank to its fullest abilities. No longer under Shadow Weaver's command, Gareth reassigned Catra to be his right hand, Scorpia to his left hand and the trio to be his direct subordinates.

They may still serve the Horde, but him and Catra were free from Shadow Weaver. Gareth smiled and pinned the badge to his

leather jacket and made his way to the new personal quarters that him and Catra now share. Gareth smiled as he opened the door, it opened with a shunt and he saw his love watching the storm outside. “One step closer to the top...I have never felt so happy in my life Gareth” Catra said before locking eyes with him. Her sapphire and golden eyes locked with his emerald ones, Gareth blushed and smiled. “Well I got a surprise that may make it even better. Meet me at the hangout” Gareth said as he fingered the ring he looted from Mystacor in his pocket.

Catra smiled, walked up to him and gave him a kiss on the cheek before running off. Gareth could feel his heart thump nervously, it was a strange feeling...to be nervous. “You can do this Gareth, after all you got this far on your own with very little of my help” Apophis said with a surprising tone of encouragement. Gareth nodded, he made his way towards the old balcony where he used to hang with Catra and Adora. Gareth walked towards this balcony, paying no mind to his surroundings. Soon he was up there, he could see Catra standing there. Thanks to a overhanging pipe, she was shielded from the rain along with the balcony.

Gareth blushed hard as he walked up to her “Catra, I want to a-ask you something” Gareth stammered which caught Catra off guard. Gareth was a strong man, sure he could be a bit of a bonehead at times, but he was usually bringing with confidence and bravery. Him stammering and blushing like an idiot was so unusual. “What’s wrong?” Catra asked, Gareth pulled out his hand from his jacket pocket. “Catra, you’re the greatest friend and the most beautiful woman in all of Etheria. You have been with me all of the way.” Gareth blushed as his heart pounded like a drum.

He got down to one knee, which got Catra’s eyes becoming wider than the very moons of Etheria. She could feel a flood of warmth

brought to her cheeks as the wind caused her hair and fur to flow backwards. “Will you marry me?” Gareth said, holding up the ring to her. The ring was stunning, made from a silver that shimmer iridescently, the ring resembled a snake eating its own tail and the ring held a stone that was black as night and adorned with the red sigil of a four horned goat skull.

Catra’s world slowed down as she stood there, taking this moment in as tears of pure joy rolled down her cheeks “Yes!! Yes!!” she cried out before hugging Gareth and giving him a deep and passionate kiss, lightning crackled all around them which reflected the surge of emotions between the two. Gareth closed his eyes and shed a few tears of his own as the two held the kiss for a few moments more. Catra slipped on the majestic ring upon her ring finger. There were no wedding ceremonies in the Fright Zone, but these two honestly didn’t need one. They shared their moment on the balcony, looking into each other’s eyes as the storm raged around them.

Catra brought her hand up to her husband’s right cheek, feeling the scar that adorned it, gently dragging her hand against it as Gareth ran his hand through his wife’s thick mane of hair. The two held hands as they entered their chamber and...made love. They did their best to keep quiet as they both lost their virginities, but their minds were lost in the raging fires of love and passion. It was doubtful that they weren’t heard. After the two had their love making, they both laid in their bed as Catra examined the ring “you know this symbol? We should make it ours” Catra suggested as she held the ring out for Gareth to see. “Yeah, yeah it would be perfect!” Gareth said with a happy grin.

“Of course you would love it my handsome barbarian” she said playfully before she kissed him on the lips. Gareth cuddled his

wife, Catra rested her head onto his chest. Hearing the beating of his heart and feeling safe in his arms was something Catra wouldn’t trade for anything in the universe. She felt so happy, in one day she gained freedom from Shadow Weaver and secured her love with her husband. Catra’s broken heart, shattered by the betrayal of Adora, has finally healed and she can set her sights on the future she will make with her husband.

Chapter 15: A Prom Of Ice And Fire

Chapter 15

A Prom of Ice and Fire

Catra and Gareth were staring, jaws agape, at Scorpia who was holding an invitation to the Princess Prom "you're a princess Scorps!?" Gareth said, still in shock. Scorpia smiled a bit nervously "yeah I am" she said a bit shyly "is that bad?" she asked her two best friends.

"No! Not at all! It's just I didn't expect a strong soldier like yourself to be a princess!" Gareth explained, Scorpia let out a sigh of relief. Catra suddenly got an idea "wait we can sneak into the prom and grab Glimmer!" she explained excitedly as Gareth and Scorpia exchanged glances and smiled. "That is an awesome idea, wildcat!" Scorpia said excitedly and hugged her, Catra pushed Scorpia back a bit. "Scorps! Remember? I only let Gareth hug me" Catra explained with a huff as Scorpia nodded "ri-right! Sorry! I forgot" she said apologetically

"Well since you two are newly weds, I'm pretty sure I can bring you both along as my Plus one!" Scorpia said with a bit of excitement "well i'm certain I can pull some strings and forge some documents. Since the ring is a signet of the Drothis Kingdom, I can claim to be the heir to it with some 'special' documentation" Gareth explained with a clever grin. Catra chuckled and nudged Gareth "clever thinking" she said.

This is one prom they were not gonna forget. The day of the prom came along, Scorpia wore a dress, Catra wore a wine red suit with fingerless gloves and she wore a wedding band that had the four horned skull symbol her wedding ring had. Gareth wore a black shirt that had a crimson vest along with fingerless spiked gloves and the matching ring to Catra's own ring. The three would enter the frozen castle that belonged to Frosta, located in the bitter colds of the Kingdom of Snows. Gareth's eyes scanned the room and they soon locked eyes with Adora's own shocked eyes.

"Horde?! Here?!" she shouted as Gareth chuckled "Hey, Sister" Gareth smugly retorted and gave a two fingered salute. "This is neutral ground, they are allowed here" Frosta said coldly. Gareth smiled and kissed Catra's cheek "enjoy the party Kit Kat" Gareth warmly said, watching Catra and Scorpia enter the party. He soon followed, grabbing a glass of fizzy drink, he leaned against a wall when he heard a familiar voice. "Hi Gareth!" the voice chirped happily as Gareth's eyes looked to the direction of the voice and saw Entrapta "oh, hi Entrapta" Gareth said in a friendly manner much to her evident surprise.

"You're not mad I joined the rebellion?" Entrapta said as she leaned against the wall with him. "Nope, I don't blame you. The Horde isn't exactly nice to outsiders buuut I got a promotion to Force Commander which means things will change" Gareth said with a warm smile and tapping his badge proudly. Entrapta warmly grinned "well i'm glad there's no harm between us! Cuz you seem like an alright guy! Despite what Adora says" she said musingly, this caused Gareth to chuckle "yeah, you aren't bad yourself Entrapta" Gareth swirled his drink in its glass before taking a sip of it

“Say Entrapta, if things don’t work out in the rebellion, call me up, i’d be glad to have you on my team” Gareth said handing her a small commlink, Entrapta smiled and walked off humming a tune. Gareth nodded over to his wife who did a small handwave. Gareth walked off and headed towards the buffet table, he examined the various foods and decided to fill a plate of them. “My my, you’re certainly quite the titan aren’t you?” he heard a distinctively male voice from behind him, Gareth turned around and locked eyes with a strange androgynous reptillian figure. “Uhm...who are you?” Gareth asked to which the figure smirked and performed a small bow.

“My name is Double Trouble, my good sir, Theatrics are my specialty.” Double Trouble said, their face decorated with a smug smirk. Gareth raised an eyebrow “My name’s Gareth, Gareth Elinas” he said softly to which Double Trouble nodded and shook his hand. “A pleasure to meet you darling, a pleasure. Horde or not, you are a fascinating figure. Are you single?” They said, trailing fingers up Gareth’s chest.

Gareth had a soft blush “y-yes, I’m a newlywed” he admitted with a nervous chuckle. “Well congrats to them! You are a steal” Double Trouble said with a hint of seduction in their voice. “Well do enjoy the party” they said walking off. Leaving Gareth in a bit of confusion, many questions ran through his head but he couldn’t make any answers in his head. Catra looked over to Adora who was walking over to her with Glimmer. “Hey Adora! Great party huh?” Catra said with a lifting of her glass. “I don’t know what you three are planning but I am gonna stop it” Adora growled as Catra sighed, rolled her eyes and sipped her drink.

“Look, i’m here for a celebration of two things, Gareth’s a Force Commander now” Catra smirked at Adora’s shell shocked expression “F-Force Commander!?” Adora sputtered, Glimmer rubbed Adora’s shoulder before she spoke “aaaand what’s the

other thing?" Glimmer asked to which Catra grinned and lifted up her hand, showing off her wedding band. "We are newly weds" Catra said "me and my husband" she snickered, trying to hold herself from laughing at Adora's jaw dropped expression as her eyes were bigger than planets. Scorpia walked around placing small devices on pillars. She knew she was being followed by Bow, so she led him to a small corner and stung him.

After having Kyle and Lonnie bring him onto Scorpia's hovercraft, Scorpia joined the party. Seeing Perfuma dance with Gareth and Catra dance with Adora, Scorpia would notice Glimmer wander off. She, of course, followed her.As Gareth danced with Perfuma, he realized he needed to get someone upset so that they could get away. He quickly thought of a question and looked at Perfuma "Hey, not to be political or anything but what the fuck is dirt?" Gareth asked nonchalantly

Perfuma went red in the face with anger "IT'S CALLED SOIL!!" Perfuma yelled but they both heard a crash. Adora had pushed Catra into a ice sculpture and grabbed her by the collar "What are you planning!!" Adora yelled as ice surrounded her, Gareth rushed to his wife's side. "You okay Catra?" Gareth asked her to which she nodded "yeah, let's get outta here" Catra said as the two left. Gareth tapped his badge "scorps? Light it up!" he yelled before explosions rocked the icy palace, deep down Gareth did hope that Entrapta at least made it out unscathed.

They boarded Scorpia's hovercraft, and Gareth couldn't help but grin as he saw Adora in her she-ra form looking on in horror. Gareth laughed "LET'S FUCKING GOOO!!" he yelled as Scorpia nodded and the ship flew off to the Fright Zone. At the Fright Zone Gareth lifted his stein of special reserve ale meant for himself, but Gareth shared it with his team. "Everyone! We did it! I expect the best and I reward the best!" Gareth shouted and lifted his stein up hgh as Catra clinked her drink with his glass.

After a crazy night of partying, Gareth was called into a meeting with Shadow Weaver and Hordak. “I’ve made the decision to transfer the prisoners to be under Shadow Weaver’s interrogative care. She can get the info out of Glimmer and her Friend” he said with a low snarl. Gareth was way too hungover to deal with this bullshit so he simply shrugged his shoulders and sighed “well if she loses them it’s her fault” Gareth said as Hordak nodded, looking Shadow Weaver right in the eyes. “Agreed, enjoy a few days off as a reward for you and your team’s service. Dismissed” Hordak said, grinning as victory was now firmly in his grasp.

Chapter 16: The Siege

Chapter 16

The Siege

Alarms blared and explosions were heard as the princesses ravaged the Fright Zone in an attempt to free their friends. Gareth barely had time to get his equipment on as Adora ripped into the prison with minimal effort. “Team with me! We gotta stop her!” Gareth yelled as he ran out of the barracks with Catra and Scorpia in tow. “Where’s Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio?” Catra called out, already worried for them. “In the prison!” Gareth yelled which caused a pang of fear to echo in her heart. As they entered the prison, it was nothing short of a warzone.

Adora slammed Kyle into a wall “Where is she?! Where’s Glimmer?!” Adora yelled, her eyes filled with pure rage. She held Kyle tightly against the wall, he could barely breathe “w-with sha-shadow weaver!” he gasped. Adora dropped Kyle and stormed her way towards the Black Garnet Chamber. Gareth ran into Netossa and Spinerella helping out Bow. “well, well, well. Nice to see you two here” Gareth said with a smirk, Netossa lared at Gareth and readied her powers. “How about a rematch?” Netossa said with gritted teeth and anger in her voice.

Gareth grinned and shrugged “last time we fought, I won but...sure why not?” he said before pulling out his greataxe and charged at her. Catra’s head was still reeling from the chaos, but she made her way to the garnet chamber as, no doubt, Glimmer would be there and so would Adora. She peeked into the chamber and could see that, somehow, Shadow Weaver had managed to

convince Adora to stand down. Catra watched from the shadows as Shadow Weaver performed some kind of spell on Adora, who cried out in pain. In an act of pure coldness, Catra simply picked up the sword of protection and walked away.

Gareth slammed Netossa into a wall with his hand clenched firmly around her throat "Ever the optimist. Wanna know what that means? It's looking at impossible odds and saying 'yeah i'll have a go'" Gareth said with a chuckle. Netossa gritted her teeth, her eyes showing nothing but disdain for the axe wielding Force Commander. "You...you make it sound like that's a good thing to have" Netossa said between gasps of air to which Gareth chuckled "oh it is. Buuuut it's not working out for you" Gareth said before a blast of water sent him flying away and skidding across the floor.

"Ha! One point to you! And one point to me!" Netossa said before she ran off with the other princesses. Gareth weakly flipped them the bird before he laid his head back and groaned. Catra could hear chaos in the Garnet Chamber as Adora and Glimmer made a break for it. Catra decided to follow them as they searched for an exit. Catra gripped the sword as the alarms blared, she gazed upon her own reflection on the blade.

"You sure made a damn mess of things, you stole my sister from me. You caused so much misery...as much as…i like this power…" Catra's voice trailed off as she talked to it, as if it could talk back to her. She began to ponder on whether she should keep the sword or return it to its owner. but she hated the silence, *despised it*, she hated it. This damn sword gave her and Gareth power, it discredited Weaver. But it took her family, her Sister. Adora… Adora, the sister of herself and Gareth. They were going to see the world together. "Please…give her back..*please*…" Catra muttered but it did not answer, she angrily smacked the blade

against the ground. “GIVE HER BACK!!!” Catra screamed at the top of her lungs, tears staining her fur. After a few moments, she caught her breath and exhaled…

At that moment, Catra made her decision.

Catra approached Adora and Glimmer, dragging the damnable blade against the metal wall. Sparks flew out as Adora and Glimmer could see Catra illuminated by the blaring lights and the sparks, giving her a terrifying appearance that paired well with the scowl her face bore. “Catra, please I…” Adora’s voice trailed off as Catra held the sword’s handle out for her, Catra didn’t speak a word as she held the sword out. Adora did a silent nod and took the sword from her, watching her feline sister retreat into the darkness. Glimmer and Adora exchanged glances, wondering why she did that.

The panicked captains and soldiers didn’t take notice of Gareth stumbling towards Hordak’s Throne room. He wasn’t around which prompted a grim curiosity from Gareth. He walked behind the throne to see Hordak’s Lab. This place looked even more terrifying under the blaring and flashing lights. Gareth could feel his heart thump harder and harder with each step. It was then he took full notice of his surroundings and his eyes went wide.

Malformed and incomplete clones of Hordak lay suspended in tubes of clear fluid and at the rear end of the room he gazed upon an array of computers. “A clone army? Or something more….” Gareth muttered before shaking his head, he swiftly left the maddening place before Hordak came back. Scorpia was helping put out fires and helping the wounded. In the chaotic noise she heard a whimpering under some rubble and could see the hapless

eyes of a horde child cadet. Scorpia rushed over to the rubble "hang on!" she yelled as she started to move rubble away from the smouldering wreckage until she was able to safely pull the child out from the rubble.

"I got ya, I got ya" she said to the child, holding her close and carrying her to safety. Scorpia smiled as the cadet ran off to join his friends, she then went to help others as the chaos finally began to fade. Gareth and Catra watched as Adora ran off with her friends on a skimmer. Gareth, through the lenses of a spyglass, could make out most of them, except for one. Gareth was shocked to see that Entrapta wasn't among the princesses. Thoughts raced through his head along with questions. Wondering if Entrapta was either captured or if war claimed the life of Dryl's princess…

Chapter 17: Vent Crawler

Chapter 17

Vent Crawler

It's been a few days since the siege and Entrapta's disappearance. Gareth volunteered for inventory inspection as Lonnie was still recovering from a broken arm that was given to her by an angry Adora. Gareth was listing food supplies when he noticed something "Huh, that's weird, we're missing a few units of ration bars." Gareth said before he heard a clunking sound from a nearby vent. Gareth brandished his pistol and peeked into the circular vent and was startled by purple lights, he jumped back as a Horde bot with purple lights rolled out of the vent being ridden by Entrapta, who was eating a ration bar.

After an awkward moment of silence and chewing, Entrapta swallowed and smiled "Hi Gareth!" Entrapta said with her trademark cheerful attitude. "Hey Entrapta...you're still here?" Gareth asked slowly, still processing what he was seeing. Entrapta nodded excitedly "Yep! Awaiting rescue and I made a friend! Her name's Emily!" Entrapta said as she introduced the robot to Gareth. Gareth cleared his throat "Well Entrapta, it's very dangerous out here. You're lucky I was here" Gareth said cautiously

Entrapta smiled "oh yes! I agree! But it's very exciting!" Entrapta smiled as she remained sitting on the top of Emily "I haven't forgotten your offer but I know my friends will come for me!" Entrapta said cheerfully. Gareth looked over his shoulder and then back at Entrapta. "Well, tell you what. I'll get you supplies

once a week, juuust in case” Gareth suggested in his usual laidback manner, Entrapta tilted her head

“Wouldn’t you get in trouble? I don’t want them to hurt you just for helping me out” Entrapta asked, a bit concerned. Gareth chuckled “pfft! Ya serious? I’m a Force commander, remember?” he said and tapped his badge with pride. Entrapta smiled and hugged Gareth before heading back into the vent with Emily. True to his word, Gareth made sure plenty of food and water was given to Entrapta every week. But the days began to pile up, Entrapta kept up her cheery attitude but Gareth could see a mounting sadness in her eyes.

Then three months passed and Gareth would find Entrapta curled up in the corner of the supply room. She was hugging her knees and her chin rested on top of her knees. Entrapta’s mask was down, covering her face. When Gareth got close, Entrapta lifted her mask and her eyes were red from crying, Emily was by her side like a dog offering comfort to its master. She looked up at Gareth and he could see that happy spark was snuffed as the familiar look of sadness and betrayal was painted on her face.

“They...aren’t coming back aren’t they?” she whimpered, Gareth got down on one knee “I’m so sorry Entrapta” Gareth softly said in a comforting voice, he extended his arms out, offering the princess of Dryl a hug. Entrapta hugged him tightly, she had lost the energy to cry, so she merely whimpered. “Is...Is the offer still open?” Entrapta asked weakly, Gareth nodded and looked into her eyes. In that moment, Gareth’s expression was like that of a big brother comforting a little sister who had a horrid day. “Of course it is,” Gareth said, trying to be as comforting as he could be for her.

After a few more minutes of silent embracing, Gareth and Entrapta went to Hordak. A few hours had passed and Gareth entered the Barracks where Catra, the Trio and Scorpia stood at attention. “At ease team! We got a new recruit! She will be helping us out, so I expect you to welcome her with open minds and arms!” he announced before stepping aside. Entrapta stepped forward with a big goofy grin, her spark of happiness was reignited, Catra blinked in surprise before she looked at Gareth. Catra gave Gareth a subtle nod towards the door, indicating she wanted to talk in private.The two entered their room, made sure no prying eyes were listening in. “So that’s the vent crawler you told me about!?” Catra whispered in a surprised tone “why didn’t you tell me it was Entrapta?” she asked which caused Gareth to look around.

“If Hordak learned of Entrapta’s presence before we could recruit her, she would be killed. Entrapta gives us a massive edge, I'm sorry I couldn’t tell you, I didn’t want you getting hurt for knowing” Gareth said as he held Catra’s hands. Catra sighed, she not only understood Gareth’s reasoning but also could see where he was coming from. Gareth had survived lashings that would have killed anyone else, He was once again putting himself in danger for her sake and the sake of their friends. “Hopefully this won’t bite us in the ass, buuut I doubt it” Catra said with a teasing smirk. Gareth smiled and they shared a kiss before returning to the others.

In the coming months, Entrapta was a significant boost in the technological capabilities of the Horde. When it came to applying First Ones technology and using it in ways that gave them an advantage, Entrapta was unmatched. Over time, Hordak and Entrapta grew close and with that not only came mass benefits but also Entrapta managed to learn things. Details involving the portal convergence that brought Adora, Catra and Gareth to Etheria and details about Gareth’s Mother.

While Gareth, on his own, learned about his mother several years ago and other details. Gareth and his Mother were both humans, a species that were unheard of. Even Hordak didn't realize such a species existed, especially before he was abandoned on Etheria by Horde Prime. Of course, Entrapta had her theories but also through research and observation on Gareth, she deduced details about Humans. They were much more physically strong and resilient than Etherians, even before he was fused with the crystal, Gareth displayed a strength stronger than many other Etherian children and recovered from injuries faster than them.

But it wouldn't explain how Gareth would be able to go head-to-head physically with She-Ra. It wouldn't explain how he can so easily channel the magic from his crystal, as Humans seem to be genetically unable to use magic given a testimony from Shadow Weaver when she tried to see if Gareth could use magic shortly before his crystal fusion. Entrapta then realized something, nothing about his Father existed. Shadow Weaver only encountered Gareth's Mother, This gave her excitement. Shortly after she wanted to find out who Gareth's Father was, she also discovered a theory regarding the Black Garnet. Entrapta decided to host a meeting to discuss this stuff.

"Hey Gareth!" Entrapta said to him as he entered her lab. "You wanted to see me?" Gareth asked which Entrapta nodded "I got two things I want to discuss!" she said excitedly. Gareth crossed his arms and gave a approving nod. "Well first off, I wanted to run a blood test to see who your father could be" Entrapta explained which caught Gareth's attention "you can do that?" Gareth asked to which she smiled.

“Well if your Dad’s in the Horde then I can find him! As for my second thing, I think I have a way to disable Brightmoon’s runestone!” Entrapta excitedly explained. Gareth smirked “Well let me go grab-” he was cut off by Entrapta. “Oh! Catra’s already here!” Entrapta said as she pointed to Catra sitting down and having her usual smug expression. “How long have you been there Kit Kat?” Gareth asked his wife, a bit surprised. “Well I was here a few minutes before you showed up.” she said happily

Gareth looked at Entrapta and urged her to continue “well by using the Black Garnet’s energy we could harness it into a weapon that can Take out the Runestone of Brightmoon!” Entrapta said excitedly with sparkling eyes. Gareth grinned “Even though Shadow Weaver is gonna be pissed, i’m sure Hordak is gonna love this” he said unaware that their conversation was being monitored by Imp. Imp would deliver this information to Hordak, who developed a wicked grin…

Chapter 18: Bloodlines

Chapter 18

Bloodlines

Gareth and his team geared up for what would be a highly violent fight. Entrapta hummed a happy tune as she slapped and welded machinery to the Black Garnet. Gareth and Catra held hands as they gazed upon the sinister runestone.

"What is the meaning of this?!" Shadow Weaver yelled angrily, causing everyone to jump back in surprise. Gareth gripped his greataxe tightly and Catra readied her claws "Sorry Shadow Weaver but we are taking the Black Garnet" Gareth said with his usual smugness that really struck a nerve with Shadow Weaver this time. "You have overstepped your boundaries Gareth!" Shadow Weaver snarled, a black magical aura surrounded her. Hordak appeared on the screens much to Weaver's shock "They have been given proper authorization by me" Hordak said with a growl.

Catra grinned as she saw the sheer horror on her face. "no...NO!" Weaver lets out a roar of anger as she blasted the room with darkness. Gareth struggled against the claws of Darkness as well as the rest of the team aside from Catra, who easily evaded the attack.

Gareth struggled against the claws of darkness as well as the rest of the team aside from Catra. Catra clenched her teeth, watching her husband struggle in pain. "Entrapta?" Catra asked Entrapta who was holding on for dear life as the claws of darkness couldn't

reach her.

"Y-yeah?" Entrapta whimpered, "hang on! I got this!" Catra said before leaping out of Weaver's line of sight, easily dodging the sinister magics that ripped through the chamber. Shadow Weaver walked up to Gareth, seeing him like this, still in pain.

Shadow Weaver began to think back to when her 3 adoptive children were still kids. Adora had the most potential but was also overthinking things, Catra was a defiant child which was a trait she shared with Gareth. Gareth, however, was the one who had a close bond with Shadow Weaver. Always calling her mom, wanting to spend time with her when he couldn't be with Catra. Gareth may have been like Catra in many ways. But Gareth treated her like a mother, until Shadow Weaver fused that crystal into him.

Even now, she could still hear Gareth's whimpers and sobs from that day. "Hey! Leave my husband alone!" Catra yelled, snapping Shadow Weaver out of her trance, she looked up at Catra. Shadow Weaver was about to lash out at Catra before Gareth broke free and grabbed her from behind. Catra frinned and jumped off the Black Garnet and slashed down on Weaver's mask, severing her crystal and her connection to the black garnet in one fell swoop.

Shadow Weaver cried out in agony and disbelief, her magic faded into nothing. "Kyle? Lonnie? Rogelio? Give Shadow Weaver a nice cell" Gareth said with a cruel grin. Shadow Weaver was carried away, she saw Gareth and Catra kiss. In that moment Shadow Weaver realized that even her own children had moved on without her. Entrapta readied the machine with Scorpia's help and then went to work on finding out who Gareth's father was. The

absence of Shadow Weaver left a gap in the rank of Force Commander, a promotion Catra gladly accepted and they got to work on readying a invasion of Brightmoon.

Entrapta happily walked with Hordak. “Tell me why you are so determined to help Gareth?” Hordak asked. Entrapta smiled “well he is a good friend! Not to mention that I am curious myself!” Entrapta giggled as she approached the Horde database and loaded Gareth’s blood sample. “And how will this help me?” Hordak asked, still unsure of all this. “Well, when you told me about Horde Prime and that database contains all the DNA profiles of all Horde members at the time, it gave me the idea. But if you really wanna know how it can help you, it’s possible Gareth’s dad is on Etheria and he would be very thankful for bringing him and his dad together” Entrapta explained in a matter-of-fact tone of voice.

Hordak acknowledged this with a grunt of approval as she began to run the test. Hordak crossed his arms and watched all the various names be compared and rejected. A prickle of dread began at the back of his mind as, 30 minutes in, they were already through the horde personnel on Etheria that were alive. This dread began to escalate exponentially as they passed the horde personnel on Etheria, both alive and dead...and it began to go through the Horde personnel that weren’t clones and that existed outside of Etheria. He dreaded the possibility, his heart trembled on who it could be. Entrapta was excited, the polar opposite of what Hordak was. Gareth’s father not being on Etheria brought so many exciting theories to her mind.

That’s when the test finally found a match! A 100% match indicating that this was no doubt Gareth’s Father. The name was displayed in bright green lettering

S K E L E T O R

Entrapta turned to look Hordak in the eyes with a happy grin only to see the absolute horror in Hordak's face. He looked like he has seen the maw of hell in all its horror. This got Entrapta worried as she held Hordak's hand. But she didn't get a response from Hordak, he just stared at the screen "H-hordak?" Entrapta asked, which prompted Hordak to look at Entrapta with eyes the size of moons. "Who is skeletor?" she asked with a very concerned tone of voice. Hordak simply backed away from the screen and walked away. Entrapta found out who Gareth's father was...but who was Skeletor? And why did his name cause such terror to Hordak?

Chapter 19: War For Brightmoon

Chapter 19

War for Brightmoon

Gareth watched as all of the Horde forces began to rally together, all ready for the invasion of Brightmoon. Catra stood by Gareth, the two held hands and exchanged glances. Gareth grinned and spoke aloud to the Horde soldiers before them

"Horde! The time has come for us to throw all we have against the rebellion! Thanks to Entrapta we have the means to crash their shield! To carve our way through the whispering woods and drive our weapons through the queen's heart!" Gareth roared and the Horde cheered in a bloodthirsty fervour. Catra stepped forward "The Rebellion's reckoning is at hand! Lock and load! rip and tear!" Catra yelled as she thrusted her fist in the air and the horde soldiers did the same. The ten thousand person army locked and loaded, boarded their tanks and began to move as Entrapta threw the switch and a blast of red lightning erupted from the black garnet and ripped through the sky.

The red lightning echoed towards Brightmoon, and a storm filled with gold crackling lightning formed over Brightmoon. Adora watched as the brave men and women of Brightmoon took up arms as the Runestone's powers were disabled. There was a massive force of Horde soldiers led by Catra and Gareth on their way. Glimmer and Bow helped with evacuation procedures, getting the civilians to safety. Everyone was afraid but Adora stood. Even if the princess alliance was disbanded, Adora and Glimmer stood their ground against the storm, as rain came down and the thunder roared.

Adora took her She-Ra form and let out a defiant shout “there will be a day to run, this will not be that day! There will be a day for mercy, today is not that day! Stand for this world, stand for your siblings, your families and your home! We will fight until our weapons break! We will fight until our bodies break! And even when we cannot stand we will spit in their faces!! For Etheria!” Adora roared as she raised her sword and the warriors of Brightmoon cheered.

The thunderous march of the Horde grew closer and closer...the forest was trampled as the soldiers of the horde charged towards the warriors of Brightmoon. The clash of steel, the roars of cannon fire and laser cannons along with the raining of arrows and artillery ripped through the air as people fell on both sides. Adora cleaved through a few horde soldiers as Swiftwind flew through the skies, Bow on his back, launching arrows at Horde soldiers who took aim at them. Adora heard the familiar yell of her brother, she turned to face him.

“This is the end Adora…” Gareth growled, Adora readied her sword “I don’t want to choose between you two and the rebellion” Adora said with a deep sadness in her voice. Even after a full year and a half of battles, she still cared for Gareth and Catra. Adora had to take this path, she had to save Etheria from the Horde. Gareth maintained his hateful glare, his green eyes shimmered with anger. “Then look me in the eyes when you do it” he said with a icy cold voice which shocked Adora.

Adora gripped her sword and charged at Gareth, her sword clashed with his axe and Gareth held his ground against Adora, even as she is in her She-Ra form. Glimmer, seeing Adora and

Gareth clash, rushed to help Adora only for her to be blocked by Catra. “Catra…” Glimmer growled as Catra coyly smirked “Adora’s sparkly girlfriend” Catra said with a teasing smirk which caught Glimmer off guard “wh-what?!” Glimmer stammered.

“How did I know? Well Adora’s little rampage was one sign, that and how Shadow Weaver was able to convince Adora to power off so easily. You have been sleeping with her quite a bit huh? Well now you two are gonna share the same grave!” Catra said with a snarl and charges at Glimmer. Glimmer was barely able to evade Catra’s frenzied claw swipes, Glimmer let out a pained cry as Catra dug her claws deep into her shoulder. Glimmer responded with a magic infused punch right in Catra’s face. Netossa charged at Gareth, who had began to overpower Adora, and attempted to stun him with a net.

Gareth knocked Adora down with a headbutt. Adora could only watch as Gareth blasted the net with lightning, swung his greataxe and slash Netossa’s right leg off at the knee. Netossa let out a cry of agony, blood sprayed from the stump as Gareth picked her up by the throat and tossed her like a rag doll towards the remains of a tank. Gareth laughed as it became obvious that the Horde was winning, the defenders of Brightmoon were losing horribly. Annihilation was at hand and Adora could feel hot tears burning down her face as she got force to her knees. Gareth had his axe ready “Goodbye Adora...i’m going to miss you” Gareth said grimly before he raised his axe over his head, ready to cut her down.

That was when the rain stopped in mid air, froze, and began to pelt the entire Horde army as massive thorned roots ripped through the ground to crush Horde soldiers and Horde machinery alike. Gareth was delivered a brutal punch as the winds picked up,

he stumbled back seeing all the other princesses arrive. He noticed that he was disarmed and saw his greataxe in Adora's hands. "May I make a suggestion?" Adora coyly said before snapping the greataxe like a twig "run" she snarled as Gareth could see his forces getting swiftly crushed.

Gareth ordered the retreat, Adora grinned as she saw the Horde retreat. But her smile swiftly faded as she saw the corpse ridden battlefield. War ravaged the beautiful landscape, blood and bodies piled everywhere and the skies were choked with ash. It was at this moment that she realized that this was going to get far worse. Out of the five thousand soldiers of Brightmoon, only 600 were left standing…

Epilogue: My Paladin

Epilogue

My Paladin

Gareth's body ached with pain as no doubt everyone else also did. The Rebellion won but it was a pyrrhic victory at best. He helped Kyle into the infirmary before heading to his and Catra's Chambers, he sat on the edge of the bed before laying in it. Gareth's eyes loomed over to the doorway as Catra walked in. Catra had a tired expression on her face, she walked over to the bed and yawned. She laid next to her husband and cuddled him.

Gareth let out a low sigh. "No one can say we didn't try" he said with a low chuckle, Catra smiled and joined in the quiet laughter. "Yeah, yeah we did. No doubt about it" Catra said with a smile. She kissed Gareth, feeling his warmth. It was well needed given all the rain they had to go through. She and Gareth shared a few quiet moments before Catra began to softly sing a song. This song she knew well, she found out about it from when Shadow Weaver used to sing to Gareth. When Gareth stopped spending time with Shadow Weaver altogether, Catra picked up the song and as it turns out, Gareth enjoyed it more coming from her rather than shadow weaver.

Catra stroked his hair as she sang to him "Paladin, Paladin. Where do you roam? Paladin Paladin, far far from home. A knight without armor in a savage land. Enemies will fall by your hand. Paladin, paladin where do you roam? Paladin, Paladin far far from home. Through the lands and worlds you'll be. Know that you will always be with me" Catra ended her song and smiled at how peacefully Gareth slept. She would stroke his cheek and smile a bit more

“sleep well my wonderful paladin” Catra whispered softly before falling asleep.

The storm continued as golden lightning ripped through the sky, taking the form of a six limbed cobra. The thunder echoed like laughter as Gareth’s crystal softly glowed...like a beating heart.

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